forming an anti-China political or military regional group since "military pacts … create more problems and complications."[190]

From fall 1966 on, however, the Indian government did attempt to look east to a greater extent, particularly on a bilateral basis. Zakir Husain, the Indian vice president, traveled to Cambodia, Malaysia, Singapore, and Thailand. The Indian foreign minister visited Thailand, Burma, Malaysia, and Singapore. He exchanged visits with his counterpart from Indonesia, which started receiving aid from India. A defense ministry delegation visited Malaysia and Singapore, and Indian naval vessels paid port calls to a number of countries in the region. Delhi also established an annual dialogue with Canberra, and hosted the Laotian king.[191]

This approach was based on the feeling that almost all the countries on China's periphery shared India's assessment of the Chinese threat. Chagla told foreign ministry officials that India could "play a big role in South East Asia towards the containment of China." Unlike the Policy-Planning Chief Jagat Mehta, the minister preferred enhancing bilateral economic and cultural ties between India and the various countries of Southeast Asia. He believed that if India proposed collective regional cooperation, the small countries might see this as an Indian attempt to seek dominance in the region.[192] Instead, he told his deputy that the countries should focus on building their own and each other's economic strength because "only an economically strong and viable South East Asia … will be able to contain China and ward off its expansionist threat." He believed such strengthening should be done in coordination with—or at least with the knowledge of—Japan, the Soviet Union, and the US.[193]

Finance Minister Desai also acknowledged that India needed to improve relations with countries in the Asia-Pacific more broadly.[194] He himself visited Japan. Gandhi traveled to Australia, New Zealand, Malaysia, and Singapore and hosted the Malaysian and New Zealand premiers in 1968 in an effort to improve contacts. Delhi also brought together the heads of Indian missions from this region to discuss increased engagement.[195] This effort would continue, as would complaints that India was not doing enough. Internal differences about whether to pursue a bilateral or a multilateral approach, as well as limited resources and capacity, served to limit India's efforts and success with Southeast Asian countries.